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SANTA BARBARA • SANTA CRUZ

DEPARTMENT OF SOCIOLOGY
264 HAINES HALL
BOX 951551
LOS ANGELES, CA 90095-1551

February 1, 2025
To: Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Committee
Re: Letter of Support for Katherine Smock

Dear colleagues,

As Director of Graduate Studies for UCLA's Department of Sociology, I write to enthusiastically nominate **Katherine Smock** for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Kate came to college at 25 without a high school diploma. She had missed years of formal education and arrived on campus without the implicit knowledge that most students absorb through schooling. This includes how to strategically read a syllabus, how to approach office hours, and how to break down an assignment into steps. Thanks to faculty who took time to teach her these skills directly, she thrived. Her experience today shapes how she teaches our UCLA undergraduates. She calls these skills part of the "hidden curriculum," and she refuses to leave it hidden.

Kate can diagnose where students get stuck and, in turn, build activities that address those specific barriers. When students in Economy and Society struggled to apply network theory to real cases, she developed a step-by-step guide walking them through the analysis of Bernie Madoff's Ponzi scheme. When she noticed that literature reviews required synthesis skills nobody had taught, she created a workshop that breaks the process into summary, analysis, and synthesis, with students practicing each skill before combining them.

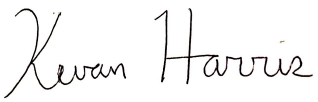
To teach the concept of socialization, she brought children's board games to class. Students played Candyland, Life, and Monopoly then work through questions analyzing how the games transmit occupational roles, normative values, and frames of competition and success. It sounds playful, but students leave understanding how socialization operates in everyday artifacts they had never thought to examine. One student wrote that Kate's class felt "more like a discussion and not any bit of an instruction." Another wrote that Kate "made me want to participate as a shy student" because "I always came out of her discussion having learned something."

Kate has served as TA for six quarters of *Introductory Sociology*, plus *Economy and Society*, *Collective Behavior*, and *Contemporary Social Theory*. Her teaching evaluations rank among the department's highest, including evaluations of her own courses. Through the CUT Fellows program, Kate designed her own seminar, "Researching Los Angeles's Housing Crisis." Students developed original research proposals while working hands-on with the LA Homeless Count

dataset. The course prepared them to apply for programs like the Undergraduate Research Scholarship, Keck, and Mellon Mays. In addition, for two years Kate co-coordinated our honors thesis program, matching graduate mentors with undergraduates conducting original research. She mentored Keck Scholarship students across the humanities and social sciences, and participated in the Social Science Interdepartmental Program's Inclusive Teaching Initiative.

Kate exhibits the best of graduate student teaching at UCLA. She is attentive, inventive, and committed to ensuring that no student fails for lack of skills they were never taught. I recommend her without reservation for this recognition and award.

Sincerely,



Kevan Harris
Associate Professor of Sociology
Vice-Chair and Director of Graduate Studies

At UCLA, I've had the pleasure to assist with and teach a variety of courses in the Department of Sociology. As a Teaching Assistant and Teaching Associate, I led discussion sections for Introductory Sociology (six quarters), Economy and Society, Collective Behavior, and Contemporary Social Theory. As a Teaching Fellow, I served as instructor for Introductory Sociology, Introduction to Sociological Research Methods, and most recently, Researching Los Angeles's Housing Crisis—a course offered in the Research Practice unit that I designed through the Collegium of University Teaching Fellows program, in which I received training on active learning and inclusive teaching. In addition to this work, for two years I co-coordinated the sociology department's honors thesis program which pairs graduate student mentors with undergraduate students completing empirical research for their honors theses, served as a graduate mentor for two sociology students completing their original research, and worked as an graduate mentor for students doing research across the humanities and social sciences as part of the Undergraduate Research Center's Keck Scholarship program. In my second year of teaching, I was additionally invited to participate in the Social Science Interdepartmental Program's Inclusive Teaching Initiative, a small group focused on the meaning of inclusive teaching and how it applies to our classes in the social sciences. Each of these experiences has sharpened my teaching goals and philosophy, which center illustrating the formative role of socialization in my students' lives and encouraging them to think like researchers—no matter their educational background before arriving in my class.

I came to college as a 25-year old nontraditional student without a high school diploma. Thanks to the close mentorship of my professors, I quickly learned the material and skills I had missed in high school. As a teacher, I aim to do the same for my students by considering the wide variety of backgrounds and educational histories in my classroom. The primary way in which I do so is by teaching and making explicit the underlying competencies needed to successfully complete assignments, instead of letting them remain a part of the "hidden curriculum." As a teaching assistant, I often outlined strategies for completing assignments that taught students how to study, communicate effectively, organize their work, and plan their time—soft skills that are critical to succeeding as a student and beyond (see Artifact 1). As an instructor, I prioritize research-based assignments that allow my students to engage their curiosity about the social world and advance their research skills. Recognizing that many of my students have never been taught how to conduct research systematically, however, I support their success and challenge them to improve the rigorousness of their work through hands-on workshops on research skills. For example, in my Introductory Sociology class, I designed a citation relay activity that drew on the energy of fun competition to encourage students to improve their citation skills. Students were divided into teams and asked to cite a source of my choosing on the board. If the citation was incorrect, students from other teams could suggest improvements.

I strongly believe that the perspectives and ideas students bring to my classroom are just as important as the material that I prepare for each lesson. To bring their insights to the forefront of our work, student-centered active learning is the primary mode of engagement in my courses and sections. This is made evident by my teaching evaluations, in which students frequently

mention that they felt comfortable to participate in my courses (see Artifact 2). For example, in the second meeting of my Introductory Sociology course, I offered a brief definition of socialization before spending the rest of the class period on an activity in which groups of students were given a board game for children to play and directed to play the board game and fill out an accompanying worksheet. Through gameplay and reflection, students discussed as a class the ways in which socialization operates through everyday experiences and cultural objects (see Artifact 3). In courses that include research methods, I include activities that encourage students to solve realistic problems that researchers face. After a lecture on ethnographic observation methods in sociology, I assigned students in small groups a hypothetical ethnographic field site prompt, such as "You will conduct an ethnography that explores how tenants navigate self-defense in eviction court." Students were then asked to consider how they would gain access to their field site, maintain access to their field site, and the extent to which they would participate in their field sites or remain an impartial observer. Across courses, I inspire students by valuing their experiences while challenging them to think rigorously, creatively, and confidently.

As someone who struggled in school for many years before finding my love for learning in college, my goal as a teacher is to facilitate for my students what my small college created for me—student-centered learning experiences that allowed me to think like a researcher and explore my intellectual curiosity. As an instructor, I see my role as a knowledgeable collaborator that can help create an environment and skillset that allows students to flourish as confident and rigorous thinkers. In both the experience of being in my classroom and the way I structure my courses as a whole, I center my students' growth as thinkers by prioritizing independent research experiences, teaching research skills, and providing many ways to vocally participate in class so even the shyest of students can practice voicing their ideas in ways that are constructive for them.

Students enroll in sociology courses because, at the very least, they find the social world interesting. I prioritize independent research in my courses and sections because I believe students' interest in the social world is an ideal avenue for showing them how systematic inquiry can be fun. I introduce independent research in my courses in ways that are appropriate to the level of the course. In my Introductory Sociology course, for example, students' final project is a literature review on a topic of their choice. In Introduction to Sociological Research Methods, my students completed self-directed, small-scale quantitative and qualitative research projects. In my Research Practice course, Researching Los Angeles's Housing Crisis, my students are crafting thoughtful, feasible, and original research proposals that make contributions to scholarly debates around housing and homelessness in the Los Angeles region. At the end of the course, students will be prepared to use their proposals to begin independent research for senior theses, with faculty mentorship, and through scholarship programs on campus like the Undergraduate Research Scholarship Program, the Keck Scholarship, and the Mellon Mays scholarship. Through these assignments, I widen access to research and leave them with skills that are useful in their academic work and their careers after college.

Widening access to research, however, also means ensuring that all my students have what they need to successfully complete these assignments—regardless of their educational background. To do so, I structure my classes to incorporate lessons and workshops that develop the underlying skills necessary for college and research. For example, I found that asking students to write a literature review—a component in my own classes and many classes I've assisted with—is easier for some students than others. I noticed that the variation in quality was largely a result of some students' inability to analyze and synthesize academic texts. To bring all students up to speed, I began incorporating a hands-on workshop that teaches students how to differentiate between and write summaries, analyses, and syntheses (see Artifact 4). After a brief lecture on how to do analysis and synthesis, students are assigned to individually summarize one of two readings that they read prior to class. After individually summarizing, they join up with someone who summarized the same reading to generate an analysis of that reading. Finally, pairs join up with a pair who summarized and analyzed the second reading to generate a synthesis statement together. In the class I'm currently teaching, I incorporated synthesis into the memos students write each week. I have noticed exceptional improvement in their ability to identify

common themes and concepts and turn that into excellent synthesis. I find that at UCLA, a public institution that serves a wide variety of students, building skills in the classroom is a critical component of inclusive teaching.

I encourage students to find their voice and share their ideas confidently by creating an environment in which students understand that their ideas are a valued part of our collective learning experience. I repeatedly find that students bring ideas and perspectives to my classroom that I would have never thought of on my own, and in doing so, they enrich our discussions and expand our knowledge. However, many students arrive to my classroom too shy or intimidated to share their thoughts. So, I begin setting the participatory tone for the class on day one by beginning the first class with a whole-class discussion about a problem that gets to the heart of the course's material. In Introduction to Sociological Research Methods, I opened the first day of class with an example of a flawed study that spawned a diet craze and asked students to read the abstract and identify why they would or would not trust the findings. Throughout the course, even in larger groups, I incorporate hands-on activities so students can learn through 'doing.' In my current course that surveys research methods in the social sciences and introduces students to housing research, I taught the basics of quantitative research by instructing students as they explored a truncated version of Los Angeles's 2025 Homeless Count dataset (see Artifact 5). By the end of the day's lesson and without any quantitative research experience, all students understood how to navigate the large dataset, identify the meaning of variables and the type of variables present in the data, and use basic statistics to describe the data. By participating in intellectual discussion and putting themselves in the shoes of a researcher, students become more confident about their ideas and sharing them in academic settings.

Grounded in my own experience of finding intellectual confidence through mentorship and student-centered learning, my teaching prioritizes widening access to research and cultivating students' curiosity about the social world. I design courses that treat students as emerging researchers by scaffolding independent research projects and explicitly teaching the skills often hidden in the curriculum. Through hands-on workshops, active learning, and multiple avenues for participation, I support students from diverse educational backgrounds in developing skills and confidence. By learning through doing—analyzing data, designing studies, and debating evidence—students gain transferable research skills and come to see themselves as capable producers of knowledge.

Artifact 1 — Skill Support

1st Reaction Paper

- Your answers should be **convincing** : how can you convince us of your interpretation, given the information you have from the article and Granovetter's concepts?
- Be sure to use the concepts of **networks, trust, and reputation**—reference specific concepts and arguments, citing Granovetter as necessary
- Proper referencing is important—**include citations** to show where you're getting your ideas from

How would I complete this assignment?

1. Read the questions in the assignment prompt
2. Read the article about Bernie Madoff
3. Review Granovetter reading and related slides
4. Return to the Madoff article and jot down where you see Granovetter's concepts and ideas appearing
5. Outline and then write your response to the prompt



In Winter Quarter of 2024, I was a teaching assistant for Professor Zsuzsa Berend's Sociology 173, Society and Economy. One of the core assignments in Professor Berend's class is an essay in which students are instructed to read a popular media article about Bernie Madoff and explain his behavior using concepts from the work of Mark Granovetter. In discussion section, I learned that students were confused about how to successfully complete this assignment, finding that it was quite different from a typical research paper. To supplement Professor Berend's instructions, I carefully read the assignment and developed three tips (seen at the top of the slide) and a guide for how to work through the assignment (bottom of slide). I received some of my highest rated evaluations ever for this course, including from one student who noted that, "Kate was an excellent TA and the only reason this course was manageable. Her sections were always correlated to the lecture and were the main reason I understood the readings and was able to grasp the material."

Artifact 2 — Evaluations

Evaluations from my courses, both as a TA and as an instructor, frequently mention student experiences that align with my goals to encourage my students to think about the impact of the social world and to become more rigorous researchers. The following are excerpts of written comments from student evaluations between 2023 and 2025.

Introduction to Sociological Research Methods, Summer 2025 (Instructor)

“This course pushed me to think more critically and reflectively about topics I hadn’t deeply considered before. Through the written assignments, I learned how to analyze issues from multiple perspectives and question assumptions I previously took for granted. The instructor encouraged open–ended thinking rather than memorization, which helped me strengthen my reasoning skills and engage more deeply with complex ideas. I also developed better writing and analytical abilities by working through memos and group work that required me to synthesize information and communicate it clearly. Overall, the course helped me grow both intellectually and personally by challenging the way I see the world.”

“She is a truly excellent educator—clear, thoughtful, and deeply committed to her students' learning. Her teaching style is engaging, inclusive, and supportive, and she consistently goes above and beyond to make sure everyone feels heard and understood. I would absolutely take another course with her. 10/10 rating!”

Introductory Sociology, Summer 2024 (Instructor)

“I have not had a class at UCLA where I felt so encouraged and welcome to participate in a while. Katherine was a wonderful instructor and I felt so included in the conversation (it really felt more like a discussion and not any bit of an instruction which I love).”

“The instructor often asked for students' input and did not judge what was shared. Additionally, many of the in-class activities were group work which encouraged collaboration.”

“The professor always held discussions during classes enabling us to have both small group and large group discussions which helped foster a good environment for learning.”

“I learned a lot of new material historically, economically, and socially that I had known about but not in depth. I gained a lot of knowledge in the short time I was in this summer class and felt I learned a lot of skills and information that I will take with me in my next sociology classes.”

“This course definitely opened my view on the world in a more sociological perspective. I learned new perspectives and also helped me in challenging my writing/ analytical skills.”

“I studied sociological concepts from the ground up. It was exciting when the concepts and theories we were studying connected to my past experiences and knowledge.”

“Professor Smock was great! She knew what she was teaching. Her activities were fun, and hands-on, and allowed me to understand the topics we discussed in her class. She cared about her students and made the learning process smooth and stress-free. She incorporated real-world problems and interesting educational videos that applied to the course.”

Economy and Society, Winter 2024 (Teaching Assistant)

“I think Kate was an excellent TA and the only reason this course was manageable. Her sections were always correlated to the lecture and were the main reason I understood the readings and was able to grasp the material. She also made understanding simpler by always expanding and correlating the topics to real like situations that were simpler to understand than the readings.”

“Katherine is what the example of a teaching assistant should be. Every discussion was well prepared and organized and she was able to make complex concepts simple. She made me want to participate as a shy student and she cares about her students no what matter the lecture material is. I always looked forward to her discussion because I would always come out of her discussion having learned something. I wouldn't have done as well in the course if it wasn't for her.”

Introductory Sociology, Fall 2023 (Teaching Assistant)

“She was very helpful in all sections. She was always in the lectures and would bring them up when we were in the discussion section. During our discussion, we would do a check-in about the readings and then go over them. She would often include extra tips and information to further our understanding. Such as jam boards, related topics, and just engaging discussion. She is very welcoming and inviting for people to engage in discussion and doesn't make you feel bad if you aren't quite there with your answer. I have asked her questions and she was always very helpful when answering. She was always very knowledgeable and made discussions engaging and fun.”

“She was a great teaching assistant! She made sure to answer all questions, and made sure that we all participated in order to ensure that we understood the material. She also made it very easy to reach out to her to clear up any confusion on the material, or any assignments.”

“The TA is really good that she teaches really well, really have a plan before every discussion and really pay attention to students.”

Introductory Sociology, Spring 2023 (Teaching Assistant)

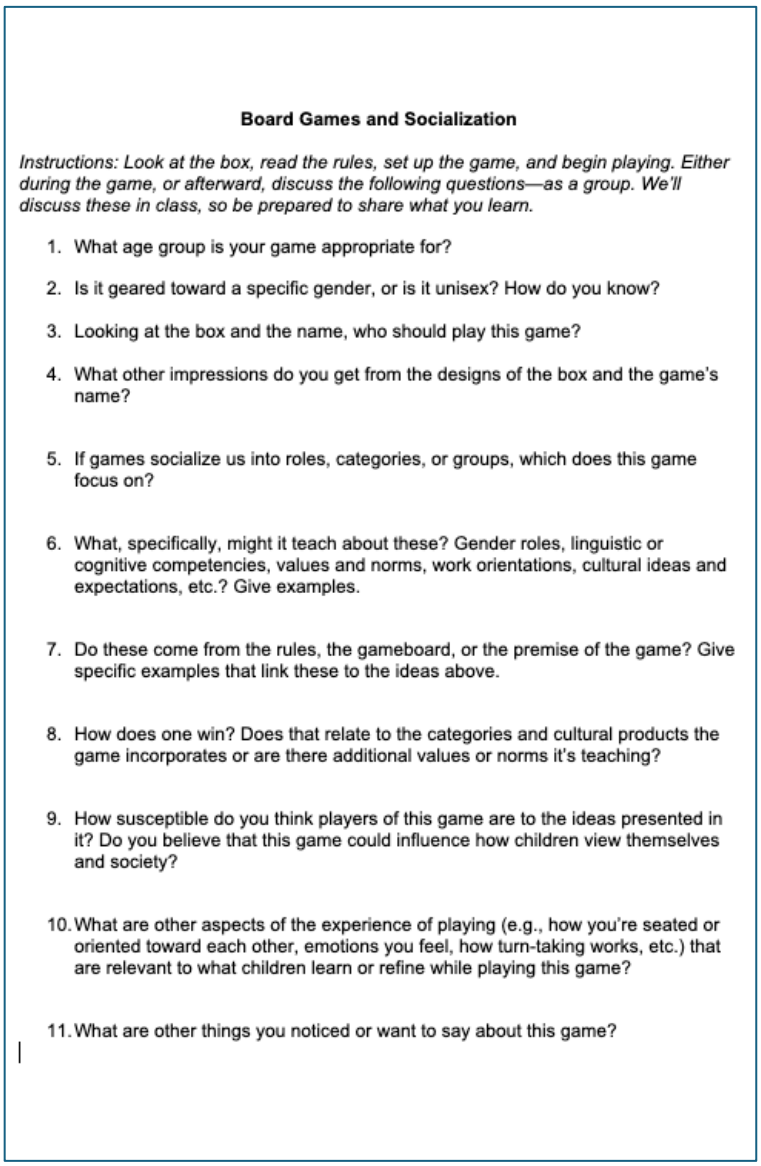
“When I first knew that the discussion section takes participation points for answering questions, I was so worried because I am too shy to hands up and answer questions. However, Katherine used some group discussions and activities to make everyone participate. That helped me a lot. I ended up being more comfortable answering questions. Thank you, Katherine! I love our discussion section!”

“Kate was definitely one of the best TAs I've had during my time at UCLA. She genuinely cared about the students and made an effort to learn everyone's names. She created an inclusive environment where everyone felt welcome to share their ideas and engage in discussions. She also made the discussion activities engaging, rather than just lecturing about the material that was covered in class. I feel like I learned a lot from the section, maybe even more so than I did from the lectures.”

“Katherine is one of my favorite TAs that I have ever had at UCLA. I am usually not someone who likes participating in class or sharing out my opinion, but she made it so easy to be a part of a class discussion that almost every student participated during our section. She was so intelligent about the material that you really felt like you were asking a professor a question during section. I really enjoyed how she always expanded the topics in class to our everyday life, because I think that is such an important component of studying sociology, studying what it means in our current society. I always felt like the discussion was worth my time and expanded my understanding of the material. I never thought I would have enjoyed this class so much.”

“I have to say that the TA does an amazing job of making the class as enjoyable as possible. Their ability to dissect and explain the topics presented in class is nothing short of amazing.”

Artifact 3 — Socialization Activity



Board Games and Socialization

Instructions: Look at the box, read the rules, set up the game, and begin playing. Either during the game, or afterward, discuss the following questions—as a group. We'll discuss these in class, so be prepared to share what you learn.

1. What age group is your game appropriate for?
2. Is it geared toward a specific gender, or is it unisex? How do you know?
3. Looking at the box and the name, who should play this game?
4. What other impressions do you get from the designs of the box and the game's name?
5. If games socialize us into roles, categories, or groups, which does this game focus on?
6. What, specifically, might it teach about these? Gender roles, linguistic or cognitive competencies, values and norms, work orientations, cultural ideas and expectations, etc.? Give examples.
7. Do these come from the rules, the gameboard, or the premise of the game? Give specific examples that link these to the ideas above.
8. How does one win? Does that relate to the categories and cultural products the game incorporates or are there additional values or norms it's teaching?
9. How susceptible do you think players of this game are to the ideas presented in it? Do you believe that this game could influence how children view themselves and society?
10. What are other aspects of the experience of playing (e.g., how you're seated or oriented toward each other, emotions you feel, how turn-taking works, etc.) that are relevant to what children learn or refine while playing this game?
11. What are other things you noticed or want to say about this game?

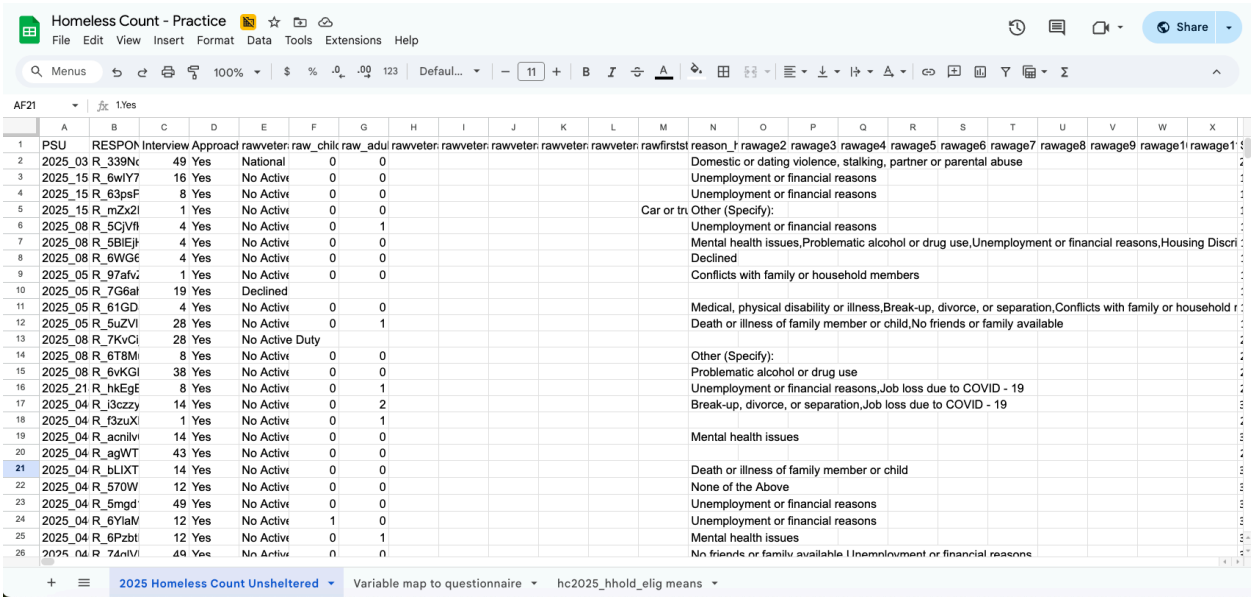
In my Introductory Sociology course taught in Summer of 2024, 'socialization' is one of the first topics we cover. Rather than lecture on the topic, I briefly introduced it and then had students spend the remainder of the class playing children's board games and discussing their experience using this guide. They found that board games teach children a remarkable number of lessons, from how to interact with one another to how to assume gendered roles.

Artifact 4 — Summary, Analysis, and Synthesis Activity



Many courses I have served as a Teaching Assistant for, and every course I have been the instructor for, has incorporated some form of a literature review assignment. After finding that students' performance on these assignments hinged on their existing knowledge about how to do summary, analysis, and synthesis, I developed an activity to teach students these skills in an interactive way. To begin, students are shown the steps of the activity they will do (slide 5). Before they do each step, they are briefly taught how to do each skill (slides 5, 6, and 7). After sharing their results with the class, I give examples of weak synthesis and strong synthesis. In this class, students were analyzing and synthesizing a chapter from Elizabeth Korver Glenn's book *Race Brokers* (2021) and Robin Bartram's book *Stacked Decks* (2022). Their synthesis statements explained how housing market intermediaries like those the authors study shape housing opportunities for home buyers and renters.

Artifact 5 — Administrative Data Exploration



In Researching Los Angeles's Housing Crisis, a course that surveys social science research methods and research on housing, students learned about quantitative analysis of administrative data sets by doing it as I taught it. To prepare, I uploaded a truncated version of the 2025 City of Los Angeles Homeless Count data to our class website. In class, they made their own copy.



After learning about how researchers use descriptive and analytical statistics I asked students to spend a few minutes exploring the dataset to identify variables that would be interesting to learn more about.

I then taught students about univariate, bivariate, and multivariate analyses, as well as variable types, which led us to explore how these could help us summarize this dataset. After running our analyses, we reflected on how our findings related to our assumptions about the unhoused in Los Angeles.

Tulin Chang Maltepe

Katherine Smock is the teaching assistant leading a research seminar I am currently enrolled in for the 2026 Winter school term. The 15-person research seminar is designed and taught by Katherine, where she guides students through crafting an independent research proposal.

Throughout the course, Katherine has inspired me to think more critically about housing-related challenges in Los Angeles and beyond. By focusing each week's class discussions on a different facet of the housing crisis, Katherine has guided me — and the rest of the class — to think more deeply about multiple aspects of housing that work together to create lived realities. Katherine is a strong discussion facilitator and pushes her students to consider alternatives to their understanding of housing issues or encourages us to push towards deeper analysis. Although we are only in the beginning stages of our research proposal, her support has been instrumental in my ability to frame a convoluted topic into a focused research question and begin research. From my experience, it is rare at such a large university like UCLA to have such a small class *and* engage in such vivid discussions like I have in Katherine's class — it's been a refreshing change of pace.

I think Katherine's approach to structuring the course with content-based discussions and methods-based activities has been an effective way to keep students curious and on track to produce a final research proposal. Each week, our class engages in an in-depth discussion of the week's readings, then Katherine leads us in activities that engage our understanding of the topic in deeper ways — like mind mapping or synthesizing arguments across readings. These activities are also intentionally beneficial to our research proposals. Katherine has also guided us towards other resources to further our research, including bringing in one of the UCLA librarians for an in-depth demonstration of navigating library resources. For a course designed to give students without prior research experience an avenue to pursue their interests and learn research methods, Katherine has made the classroom environment an excellent space for learning for any level of experience.

It is clear to me that Katherine prioritizes the learning of her students at every step of the teaching process. She has repeatedly emphasized her desire to support students to carry this research forward either as a senior thesis or for graduate school applications. She is equally committed to students who are just curious about research and those that are eager to pursue graduate studies. As someone uncertain about their future research interests, I feel completely supported, challenged, and inspired by Katherine's guidance.

Sincerely,
Tulin Chang Maltepe

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name: **Katherine Smock**

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I was Katherine Smock's student in SOCIOL 20 at UCLA, a class about sociological methods. Katherine was the main instructor for our cohort as there was no professor assigned to instruct the class. Katherine led multiple sections with 2 2-hour classes per week.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

I truly feel that Katherine instructed with the purpose of long-term material comprehension rather than short-term retention for exams or assignments. Almost a year out since being Katherine's student, I still remember and use the methodologies taught to me in SOCIOL 20 daily in other classes. I usually find readings a slog to get through and find homeworks a tedious task, but Katherine

broke readings down in class in a way that made them digestible and applicable to everyday life, even when works were translated or dated. We went over homework in class together and didn't just have students read off answers, but treated the discussion as a debate around the topics examined in class. Though the class covered more methods and practice than theory, this wasn't taught like an elementary math class where there is one right answer - instead, Katherine spoke in detail about *why* sociologists developed the methods we use, explaining how our tools came to be and examining their strengths and weaknesses. I left Katherine's class with many more academic tools in my arsenal, and though I felt that I had truly learned, I never felt distressed by workload or time management.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

1. **Katherine assigned a group project, during which our group put into use the methodological concepts learned in class to conduct a sociological survey and analysis. During this, Katherine closely monitored how each group was progressing, how much effort each group member was investing, and how group dynamics played out to affect our work. Even when some groups' projects veered off-topic, Katherine allowed them to investigate their tangents as long as they**

continued to use course materials in their own way. I found the lack of restrictions on our project very freeing and conducive to comprehending material in one's own way, yet the knowledge that Katherine would have a close eye on our work kept us making an effort to do good work.

2. **On a personal level, I had an emergency nose surgery the first week of class and had to amend my schedule. Katherine was very kind in her response and kept me accountable to complete my work without rushing or doubting me. She is, so far, the only instructor at UCLA who made me feel fully trusted and supported.**

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Katherine is an excellent instructor, an excellent sociologist, and an excellent person. She will have a bright future in her career, wherever it takes her. Awarding her now would begin what is sure to be an esteemed career.

Dear Selection Committee,

I am writing to enthusiastically recommend graduate student Kate Smock for a 2026 Distinguished Teaching Award for Graduate Teaching Assistants. As someone who served on the committee bestowing these awards for three years, I am well aware of the impressiveness of the candidates and the steep competition Kate has among her peers. At the same time, as someone who has interacted and worked with Kate in a variety of ways—as former Vice Chair of Undergraduate Education, as faculty for a course Kate served as a TA for, and as the instructor of the course development class that Kate took twice—I also know how well-deserving Kate is for this award.

Many qualities contribute to Kate standing out among her peers, but an important foundation is that she never forgot what it was like to be a student. Kate attended Lewis and Clark, a small liberal arts college. It was there that she experienced firsthand that rigor, warmth, and a sense of belonging could not only go hand-in-hand as students learned, but also that this approach can cultivate an effective learning space for students at all levels. In a classroom like that, a novice can gain confidence and even mastery, while more advanced students feel inspired and able to do more complex work.

A product of that environment, Kate offers students a robust experience in her classes. She creates lectures, assignments, and activities that not only engage students and teach them sociology, but also offer academic and professional development to help students be more successful in classes and beyond. Unlike some instructors who believe the key to student admiration is blurring boundaries between student and graduate student instructor or creating a class built on low-expectations, Kate sets a professional tone and holds her students to high standards. At the same time, she demonstrates to students that they are able to achieve these standards with engagement an effort, thus gaining student respect while enhancing both their learning and self-efficacy.

Kate has a calm charisma that gets students on board with this venture in a way I find enviable. Although this personal character and talent may be impossible to teach, I have been most impressed watching Kate serve as a mentor to other graduate student instructors. Each Spring I teach a quarter-long workshop to help graduate students prepare to teach their summer classes. The only students required to take this class are first time instructors, but I encourage seasoned instructors to participate if they are able. Kate was an astute, engaged participant her first time in the course, with many thoughtful questions and ideas from her time as a student and TA for designing her first course. The second time she participated, I was blown away by what she added to space, proving to be an incredible resource for her peers. She was an exemplar of how seasoned instructors can add to those conversations.

In sum, Kate an amazing instructor/TA, a UCLA gem, and so deserving of this award.

Sincerely,



Jessica L. Collett
Professor, Sociology